here), the Saraswati Civilisation or even Meluhha. So that means saying something about the controversial issue of origins, about which a great deal of chauvinist nonsense is now being promoted in some quarters.

I have also explored the religious impulse in its main manifestations, ranging from the religion of the Vedas through to the revolutionary heterodoxies of Buddhism and Jainism and on by way of bhakti through to the impact of sea-borne monotheism first introduced by early Christian missionaries and subsequently by Arab traders and their missionaries, and what came after in the form of Western colonialism.

None of those forebears of mine I mentioned earlier who were part of that colonial process in India consciously saw themselves as instruments of imperialism, but that is what they were. The British Raj was not, as Lord Curzon once argued, 'the greatest force for good the world has ever seen'. Nor was it, as the nineteenth-century Bengali philosopher Keshab Chandra Sen liked to say, the coming together of 'parted cousins'. For all the good intentions of men like my father – and there were of plenty of them on the ground – British imperialism was very good for Britain but very bad for India, even if it was never the vast satanic mill that some make it out to have been.[5] Like the curate's bad egg in the old *Punch* joke, 'parts of it are excellent', and there is a case for preserving those same parts from historical oblivion, particularly with regard to the Orientalist movement of the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries and its role both in the recovery of India's past and in helping to kick-start the Bengal Renaissance. Just as the munshis and pandits who taught them were not given their due in the nineteenth century, so today the tendency is to overlook the pioneering role of the Orientalists themselves. Readers who know something of my earlier work will not be surprised that I have more to say on this